



Reflexive AI

World Cafe facilitation · volunteer-run

In-company World Cafe

A facilitation guide for running a world cafe about reflexive AI in your organization.

// WHY THIS WORLD CAFE

Uncover how your organization can use AI in a human-centered, responsible manner.

It gathers evidence for a governance framework — and gives people in your organization space to discuss what human-centered AI means for them.

Face-to-face, ≈100-120 minutes

Group discussions and individual reflection, with clear improvement actions at the end.

15–25 participants, 5 topics

A World Café across five stations, each moderated by a host.

PURPOSE OF THE STUDY

Help us uncover how organizations can use AI in a human-centered, responsible manner.

A collaborative action research project run by volunteering academics and professionals, and overseen by a 9-member peer review board.

reflexiveai.org · info@reflexiveai.org

About this guide

Thank you for contributing to the Reflexive AI Research Initiative. We are grateful for your time and effort.

This facilitation guide helps you run a world cafe about reflexive AI in your organization. It provides invaluable data for our research initiative to build a governance framework for human-centered AI. It also provides a good opportunity for people in your organization to reflect on what this means for them.

The world cafe typically takes 100-120 minutes. We assume, and recommend, a face-to-face setting with 15-25 participants. If you have fewer participants, the World Cafe uses fewer stations (see further down).

Because the world cafe is part of a scientific study, it is important to:

- Ensure **all participants understand** they are taking part in a scientific study, and the (anonymous) results from the discussions will be shared with the research team.
- Data collection relies on **written materials** only, so instruct participants to write clearly and avoid disclosing sensitive information.
- **Do not bias participants** by pushing them in a certain direction (i.e. "AI is great" or "AI is terrible").
- **Do not modify the format** unless absolutely necessary. Deviations may risk making the data unusable for the initiative due to methodological inconsistencies.

Do not hesitate to contact the coordination team at info@reflexiveai.org with questions.

How to prepare

How to invite people

- Clarify the aim of the world cafe: to uncover how organizations can use AI in a human-centered way. Keep your invitation free from personal beliefs or bias.
- For the best outcomes, maximize the number of people with decision-making authority around AI.
- Emphasize that the discussion is part of a scientific study. Insights will be shared with the research initiative.

An example invitation is: *"Artificial intelligence (AI) is changing our work and workplaces, which creates opportunities but also risks. I'd like to invite you to a 120-minute world cafe where we think about how our organization can use AI in a responsible, human-centered manner. This is part of a global Reflexive AI Research Initiative, and our anonymous results will be shared with them. The questions we tackle will also help our own thinking about this in our organization. Your views, perspective and contribution are highly appreciated."*

Materials

- Print the [station topics](#) (5 total).
- Print the [station host protocol](#) (5 total, one for each host).
- Print the [informed consent forms](#) (1 per participant).
- Bring empty flip charts or whiteboards (10-20).
- Bring stickies, markers and pens.
- A timer is useful to track time.
- A buzzer or tingsha bell is useful to indicate new rounds.
- Optionally, bring snacks and drinks for a relaxed atmosphere.
- Optionally, name stickers or badges.

Practical preparation

- Create five stations for the "World Cafe" (or 3 if you have fewer than 15 participants). This could be five tables with 4-6 chairs, five flipcharts or whiteboards. Ensure there is one topic sheet and one station host protocol at each station. Add markers, stickies, snacks and drinks.
- Ideally, already pick participants upfront to act as the five station hosts (for "World Cafe") and ensure they've read the station host protocol.



🕒 5 min

Step 1. Welcome

Welcome the participants to the world cafe. Thank them for making time to contribute. Introduce yourself.

Introduce the topic for this world cafe: to explore what human-centered AI use looks like in your organization, and what can be done to ensure it.

It is important to keep this part short and free of bias. The next step is an opening exercise to get everyone's thinking started.



🕒 5 min

Step 2. Informed Consent

In this step, participants have the opportunity to give their consent to participating in a scientific study. Good research requires informed consent at the start.

Steps

- Ask all participants to complete the [informed consent form](#). If a person does not wish to consent, this is perfectly fine. However, they cannot continue participating in the session.
- Collect the forms.



🕒 20 min

Step 3. Impromptu Networking

We begin the session with an opener to help participants get their thinking started about human-centered AI, and build on each other.

Steps

- **1 min** Ask *"What does human-centered AI look like for you? How does this relate to your work or this organization?"*. Give participants 1 minute to reflect on this in silence.
- **4 min** Ask participants to form pairs and take 4 minutes to share their views. With an uneven number of participants, there will be one group of three.
- **4 min** Ask participants to form new pairs, and take 4 minutes to share their views and build on the previous round.
- **4 min** Ask participants to form new pairs, and take 4 minutes to share their views and build on the previous round.
- **2 min** In their current pair, ask participants to take a sticky or index card and write down how they define human-centered AI.
- **5 min** With the whole group, ask the pairs to share some of their definitions.
- **collect** The stickies or index cards with definitions (i.e. on a wall, on the floor or with you).



60 min

Step 4: World Cafe

We use World Cafe as the primary format for the focus groups. We assume 15-25 participants. If you have fewer participants, limit to three stations (topics 1, 4, 5). In this format, each participant discusses 3 out of 5 topics in small groups at different stations, each moderated by a host. So with five stations, you have five hosts.

How to run

- Introduce the aim: to engage in multiple rounds of small-group discussions around 5 topics, each at a different station, and capture the output on sheets.
- Explain the general format. Participants will distribute evenly across the stations. There, a host facilitates a small-group discussion and records insights on a sheet. After 15 minutes, a new round starts and participants move to another station and a new topic.
- Invite participants to distribute evenly across the stations. If you did not pick hosts upfront, ask each small group to choose one of their own to act as host. The hosts facilitate and moderate the discussion, asking open questions while keeping their own opinions to themselves. Ensure that each group familiarizes themselves with the station host protocol.
- **15 min** Begin round 1 ("Discussion"). Invite the participants at each table to discuss their topic openly and collaboratively for 15 minutes. The hosts moderate the discussion, write down group insights and ensure that the host protocol is followed. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **15 min** Begin round 2 ("Discussion"). Ask the participants to redistribute evenly across the stations, picking a station at random that they have not already visited. Invite the participants to discuss their new topic with the station host, who continues moderating the discussion and adding insights to the sheet. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **15 min** Begin round 3 ("Discussion"). Ask the participants to redistribute evenly across the stations, picking a station at random that they have not already visited. Invite the participants to discuss their new topic with the station host, who continues moderating the discussion and adding insights to the sheet. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **20 min** Bring everyone together again and ensure everyone has a marker or a pen in hand. Ask the hosts to bring the sheets from their station. Ask a host to step forward and summarize the core insights from their table. When done, all participants (but the host) step forward to distribute three dots across the insights they deem most important on this sheet. Repeat this until all hosts have summarized their insights and all sheets have been dot voted on.
- **collect** The posters created at each station (with dot votes) and any notes by the hosts.

Station topics

1. What should "human-centered AI" look like in your organization? What results or outcomes would you see? What do you hear people say or ask regarding AI?
2. Under what conditions has AI been used in your organization in a manner that supported people?
3. What are examples in your organization where the use of AI was not human-centered, or where could you see it easily sliding down that path?
4. What procedures, rules or processes should be implemented to ensure responsible, human-centered AI in your organization?
5. What could be measured, tracked or audited to ensure that the way your organization uses AI is responsible and human-centered?



15 min

Step 5: 15% Solutions

Following the discussions about human-centered AI in the previous rounds, we now translate insights into practical action.

How to run

- Ensure all participants have access to empty index cards or stickies, and have a pen at hand.
- **3 min** Invite participants to silently and individually reflect on the question *"Think about human-centered AI for this organization. Let us imagine 85% of the solution is out of our control, but the other 15% we can act on without permission or additional resources. Where do you have discretion and freedom to act? What can you do to take action right now without more resources or authority?"*.
- **2 min** Ask participants to write down their action(s) clearly on a sticky or index card **twice**; one to keep for themselves and one for you to collect at the end.
- **5 min** Invite participants to form groups of 2-3 to share their actions and help make them more actionable.
- **5 min** With the whole group, ask for some examples of actions people have identified.
- **collect** The index cards or stickies with actions (i.e. on a wall, on the floor or with you).



5 min

Step 6: Closing

Close the session by thanking everyone for their time, and the station hosts for their gracious facilitation. Reiterate that the anonymous results will be shared with the research initiative, and research updates will be made available on reflexiveai.org.

We recommend going through this checklist:

- **collect** Filled-in [informed consent forms](#) for every participant.
- **collect** The index cards or stickies with definitions (from "Impromptu Networking").
- **collect** The posters from each station (from "World Cafe") with dot votes, and any notes by the hosts.
- **collect** The index cards or stickies with actions (from "15% Solutions").



Step 7: Send results to us

When you've completed the focus group, please share the following with us to contribute to the research:

- Clear pictures or scans of the station sheets, including dot votes. Please remove or blur person names and company-sensitive information (if any).
- A brief review by you and any other facilitators as to how the session went. What worked? What did not work? Where did you observe tension or friction?
- Scans or pictures of filled-in [informed consent forms](#) for all participants. Unfortunately, we cannot process *any* data without informed consent.
- Send the materials to info@reflexiveai.org.